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ROXBURY

These kids don't take any garbage

By Sarah Childress
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Jane Ehrenfeld's first-grade class couldn't sit still. They'd just finished music, and now it was time to talk about their upcoming field trip. The one to . . .

"The mayor's house!" cried one. "No, the councilor's house," another corrected. Finally, one came up with the right answer: City Hall.

Their trip was to City Councilor Chuck Turner's office Wednesday, and it wasn't a sight-seeing tour. The Nathan Hale Elementary students went to lobby for a cleaner Roxbury neighborhood with hand-written letters and old-fashioned persuasion.

For the last four months the students have been learning about their community — and how to change it — through a service project created by Ehrenfeld, who teamed up with AmeriCorps volunteer Jennifer McGonagle through Peace Games, a violence-prevention organization.

"I want them to make that connection in their heads about what they're doing in school and what's going on in the street," Ehrenfeld said. "They can be agents of change, but they haven't seen it yet."

So the class compared its vision of the ideal community — parks, a fire station, nice roads — to their reality: tin cans, plastic cups, cigarette butts, and glass shards lying tangled in the weeds along the streets.

"We . . . saw all the garbage, and it was bad," said first-grader Christopher Acosta, his face serious. The other students agreed. Not only was it ugly, it was dangerous: It can puncture bike tires, cut you if you fall down, or fly into your eyes when the wind rises. The trash had to go.

Their letters to Turner included suggestions such as putting garbage cans on street corners and having the city hire an additional cleanup crew. "We want a butuful street," said one letter. "And we want to see flowers." At City Hall, they wriggled into seats around a conference table, with Turner at the head. After a few read their letters aloud, the class listened wide-eyed as Turner shared his ideas.

"There are a variety of steps we can take," he said later. "The trash barrels are definitely something we can do."

He hopes to meet with the class next fall to check on the cleanup progress.

Tatevick DeLaRosa, who perched in the seat beside Turner, said she enjoyed meeting him, and was certain he would help.

Regardless of whether Turner ultimately satisfies their requests, the students plan to do their part, by planting morning glories around the brown-brick school.

Miguel Villar, left, Tatevick DeLaRosa, right, and their first-grade classmates at Nathan Hale Elementary pay close attention during Wednesday's meeting with City Councilor Chuck Turner.

DORCHESTER

For blacks, a virtual icebreaker

By Shari Rudavsky
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Usually when people speak about bridging the so-called digital divide — the gap in technology between the well-to-do and less fortunate — the solution centers around providing computers. Ken Granderson takes a different tack.

The president of Inner City Software, a Dorchester company, Granderson teaches the low-income community the power and value of computers.

"Technology is a tool, and it's a great tool with a lot of potential but you can't put that tool in front of people without first preparing them to use that tool," Granderson said. "We needed to figure out ways to present technology to people that was relevant to where they were and what they were interested in."

For the past five years Granderson has been doing that. In 1997 he started Boston Blacks OnLine, an online cafe of sorts that has developed into a "virtual community." About 4,200 members worldwide have applied to the group, in which conversations range from movies to sports to politics.

Then in February, with a grant from Fleet's CommunityLink program, Granderson spearheaded Roxbury.com, a virtual kiosk for the neighborhood. The site contains news, events, a list of local churches, and a directory of area businesses and organizations, from restaurants to child-care centers.

During the summer, Granderson plans to launch Dorchester.com, a similar site for that neighborhood. Mattapan.com may follow.

Since Roxbury.com came online in February, it has had about 80,000 hits, gaining in popularity as word about it spread. In April there were about 18,000 hits, representing 8,711 hits, Granderson said.

"It's a single place that someone in this community can look and see what's happening," said Laurie Sparrowhawk, coordinator of the Cruz Computer Learning Center in Roxbury, which posts information about its classes on the site. "It's a way for Roxbury to have its own specific interests and identity out there on the Internet."

Accion, an organization that provides loans to small business entrepreneurs, has a Web site of its own. Still, the Charlestown nonprofit organization uses Roxbury.com to publicize its free orientation sessions.

While only a handful of people have made their way to Accion through the Web site, company officials plan to continue using the site. "I do think it will take off. These things take time," said C.J. Lind, Accion's New England program associate.

If BBO's success is any indication, Lind's words will prove true. During the past five years people from as far away as Japan have signed on to the list-server to learn what's on the minds of the city's black community.

The list has also become a meeting grounds of sorts. One couple that had fallen out of touch reconnected online and now plans to marry, Granderson said. Others have parlayed people they meet in cyberspace into professional contacts.

Recently conversation ranged from the Celtics to the film "About a Boy," and from racial profiling to discussions of what Boston has to offer its black community. "The uniqueness of it is because of the black perspective that it provides," said Walter Kwami, 36, of Quincy, a list participant. "Everybody gets an education from the process."

That's precisely the idea, said Granderson, who refers to his projects as "breaking the virtual ice." On May 31, the 39-year-old Dorchester resident received a Champion of Freedom award from Freedom House to salute his work.

For Granderson, however, the true reward will be hearing users say, "Hey, what's happening this weekend? Let me go check Roxbury.com."

Ken Granderson, honored by Freedom House with a Champion of Freedom award, on the job at Inner City Software.

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